

Introduction to Theology

Notes for First-Year Students of Theology

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore ST 01: Introduction to Theology

These notes are for reading, not only for revision. Read them slowly, with a pen, and write your questions in the margins. Theology is a conversation you enter, not a list you memorise.

1. You Are Already a Theologian

From the first day of this course you should think of yourself as a theologian, not as someone who is merely preparing to become one. Theology is not a body of information handed to passive minds. It is a passion, carried out with curiosity, commitment, and engagement. Augustine spent his life trying to understand the mystery of the Trinity, and the old story tells of him on the seashore, watching a child try to empty the whole sea into a small hole in the sand, and learning that the human mind can no more contain the infinite God than that hole can contain the ocean. That humility is the beginning of good theology.

A theologian who is satisfied that his thought is complete and final has stopped being a good theologian. The better theologian keeps an open and unfinished mind, always reaching toward the greatness of God and of the truth, always growing. Theology is fruitful only when it is done with an open mind, on the knees in prayer, and with a generous heart. The mind alone is not enough, and prayer without rigour is not theology either. The two belong together.

At Morning Star, the study of theology is not academic climbing for its own sake. It serves a fourfold aim. It seeks a deep and orderly understanding of Catholic doctrine drawn from Scripture, Tradition, and the Magisterium. It seeks to root that understanding in the cultural, social, and subaltern reality of the Bengal region, so that the Gospel can be spoken in a language the people understand. It seeks to turn every reflection toward pastoral action, toward preaching, the sacraments, healing, and the leading of communities. And it seeks mutual enrichment through dialogue with other religious traditions and with the human sciences. The motto of this house, taken from Matthew 5:16, is "Let your light shine." Theology here is meant to become light for the local Church.

2. What Theology Is, and What It Is Not

It helps to begin with what theology is not. Theology is not brainwashing, and it is not an adult catechism. It is not merely a thorough knowledge of basic Christian doctrines, though it includes such knowledge. Theology is a living process that moves from information to formation to transformation. It deals with the basic questions that every human being

raises about life, the world, and God, and the intimate, personal experience of God, both of the individual and of the community, stands at the centre of the whole work.

The word itself is built from two Greek words, *theos*, meaning God, and *logos*, meaning word, discourse, or study. Theology is therefore discourse on God, the study of God, God-talk. Christian theology is the discussion of the Trinitarian and Christological mysteries and the interpretation of Sacred Scripture and Christian doctrine. Its starting point is faith experience, by which we come to understand the words and the actions of God revealed in human history for the salvation of the world.

Karl Rahner taught that the only truly absolute mysteries in Christianity are grace and Christ. Grace is the self-communication of God in the depths of human existence, and Christ is that same self-communication in history. Theology is the attempt to understand God giving himself in this twofold way. Christian theology helps human beings to understand how God, through Jesus Christ, is at work by the Holy Spirit in life and history. Its focus is on Jesus Christ, on the Kingdom of God, and on the mission of the Church patterned on the Abba experience of Jesus and directed toward the salvation of human beings. As M. M. Thomas put it, Christian faith rests on a prophetic claim, that God has acted in a unique way in a real historical event, in the incarnation, life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, in order to begin his Kingdom.

3. Faith Seeking: The Many Definitions of Theology

The oldest and richest description of theology is the phrase of Anselm of Canterbury, *fides quaerens intellectum*, faith seeking understanding. Each word carries weight. Faith is the starting point, the active love of God reaching for a deeper knowledge of God. Seeking holds the middle ground between two errors. Fideism accepts everything that God reveals without ever asking reason to examine it, and so it silences the mind. Rationalism rejects everything that reason cannot fully grasp, and so it silences faith. Theology refuses both. It believes in order to understand, and it understands in order to believe more deeply.

The mystery of Exodus 3, the burning bush, is a fine teacher of what this seeking means, because faith seeks many things at once. Faith seeks understanding, as Moses turns aside to look at the bush that burns and is not consumed. Faith seeks love, for the bush burns with a fire that does not destroy. Faith seeks justice, for the Lord says, "I have heard the cry of my people," and sends Moses to set them free. Faith seeks ritual expression, for the Lord says, "Remove the sandals from your feet, for the place on which you are standing is holy ground." Faith seeks dialogue, for Moses is sent to speak both to the rulers and to the people about God and the plan of God. And faith seeks harmony, for the people are led toward a land flowing with milk and honey. Our faith seeks to understand, to love, to express, and to communicate with reality in three great areas, God, the human being, and the cosmos.

From this single root grow many true definitions, each stressing one thing that faith seeks. Gustavo Gutierrez defined theology as critical reflection on Christian praxis in the light of the Word, and so theology becomes faith seeking justice. This is liberation theology,

concerned with the Kingdom of God as freedom, fellowship, and justice, drawn from Luke 4, Matthew 25, and the opening of *Gaudium et Spes*. It prefers right action to mere right opinion, the worm view from the ground to the bird view from the sky, the bullock cart to the helicopter, the here and now to the distant abstraction. Faith here is bound up with solidarity with the poor and commitment to the cause of justice. When faith seeks dialogue, theology becomes ecumenism and the theology of religions. When it seeks love, it becomes the theology of the supreme commandment, the way of *prema*, of *agape*, of Abba. When it seeks interiority, it becomes spiritual theology. When it seeks harmony, it becomes ecological and subaltern theology. When it seeks integrity and wholeness, it becomes eschatology, the theology of the Omega. When it seeks ritual expression, it becomes the theology of worship, liturgy, and the sacraments.

Other thinkers add their own accents. Michael Amaladoss describes theology as the searching of believers for an experiential understanding of God that is relevant to transforming their lives in the world. Roger Haight describes Christian theology as the attempt to understand the whole of reality, the world, human existence, history, and God, within the vision carried to the Christian community by its central symbols, Jesus, the Eucharist, and the sacraments. Read through the lens of *Gaudium et Spes*, theology becomes hermeneutics, the interpretation of Christian faith in the light of present reality, and the interpretation of present reality in the light of the Word of God. This is what it means to read the signs of the times in the light of the Gospel.

4. A Working Definition

Drawing these together, we can state a working definition. Christian theology is the systematic and searching interpretation of the meaning of human life and of reality as a whole, from the standpoint of the revelation given in Jesus Christ, joined to the continual reinterpretation of Christian faith in the light of the new experience and the changing situation of the world, carried out in and by the believing community. Said more simply, Christian theology deals with the ultimate meaning and mystery of human life and of all reality, the human, the cosmic, and the divine together, from the standpoint of Christian revelation as it is held in the Bible and in Christian Tradition. Faith is the condition that makes theology possible, which is why the honest question must be asked at the start: can one do theology without faith?

5. The Task and the Aim of the Theologian

Blaise Pascal wrote that the heart has its reasons of which reason knows nothing, and that we know the truth not only by reason but also by the heart. The theologian honours this. Yet the conclusions of the theologian must still be reasonable, that is, the work of a mind open to all the human faculties as it reaches for truth. The theologian must seek, in a searching and orderly way, to explain his faith in a language and in concepts that carry meaning for the community, in its particular setting, and above all in India. Following the counsel of the

First Letter of Peter, the theologian must be able to give an account of the faith, the hope, and the love that are in him, so as to throw light on the great mysteries of life and death, of suffering and evil, of liberation and redemption, and of belief, religion, and unbelief. Through his own experience of God, he enters into the deeper meaning and the greater practice of faith, hope, and love.

The aim of this course follows from all of this. It is to answer one basic question, namely what theology is and how it is done. It is to see theology as faith seeking understanding, justice, dialogue, love, interiority, harmony, and integrity, with constant reference to the central mission of Jesus, the Kingdom of God grounded in his Abba experience. It is to learn to theologise in the many-religioned, many-cultured, socially varied setting of India. It is to become familiar with the sources, the models, and the methods of theology, and to see how the different courses of the theological programme are connected and how they bear on personal and social transformation. And it is to learn the method of research and the writing of scholarly papers.

6. Can We Speak of God? The Language of Theology

Before theology says anything about God, it must face a hard truth. Any image we make of God is more unlike God than like him. The mystical traditions, the author of *The Cloud of Unknowing*, and classical theology all stress that God is invisible, as Romans and Colossians say, incomprehensible, as the Psalms and Job say, dwelling in unapproachable light, as the First Letter to Timothy says, with thoughts and decrees that cannot be fathomed. The classical Hindu tradition says the same in its own way with the phrase *neti neti*, "not this, not this." There is a real sense in which, the moment we try to capture God in a definition, the living God slips past it.

This gives theology two paths, and it must walk both. The apophatic way, the negative way, the way of *neti neti*, points out the failure of every attempt to describe the absolute mystery of God, and so it guards the divine transcendence. The cataphatic way, the positive way, takes the revelation that God has truly given and dares to make statements about him, calling him Father, Shepherd, King, and Judge. The Bible and the mainline Christian tradition affirm that we can indeed speak of God, but only by using religious and symbolic language, words such as love, light, father, and shepherd, which point truly toward God without ever containing him.

How can ordinary words apply to the infinite God at all? Here theology distinguishes three ways a word can be used. A word is used univocally when it has exactly one meaning, as with the words six, mango, or horse. A word is used equivocally when the same sound carries entirely different meanings, as with the words bank, ring, or trunk. Between these lies analogy. When we call God Father, or Mother, or Shepherd, we are speaking analogically. The word is neither exactly the same as its human use nor entirely different from it. Analogy rests on the bond between the Creator and the creature, for creation is the expression of the love of God and reflects the rays of his perfection and beauty. From the created order, therefore, we can come to know something true about God, and we can speak

of him, while always remembering that he remains greater than our speech. The First Vatican Council, in *Dei Filius*, and *Dei Verbum* both teach that God, the first principle and last end of all things, can be known with certainty from the created world by the natural light of human reason.

At its root, all theology is the putting into words of an experience of God. Every people has some experience of the divine, what Rudolf Otto called the encounter with a mystery at once tremendous and fascinating, the immediate awareness of being touched and gripped by the holy. Scripture is full of such moments: the strange burning bush of Exodus 3, the blinding brightness of the Transfiguration, the *divyarpadarshana*, the vision of the divine form, in the eleventh chapter of the Bhagavad Gita, the hearts burning within the two disciples on the road to Emmaus. Because God is incomprehensible and transcendent, this experience cannot be captured in everyday speech, and so theology takes ordinary language and uses it in an extraordinary way. And because the Christian experience of God happens within history, since God has acted in history in Jesus Christ, the expression of faith can never be only a confession of doctrine. It must also be a commitment lived out in history.

7. The Seven Polarities Theology Must Hold

Good theology lives in tension. It does not collapse one truth into another but holds opposites together, the way a bridge holds its load by pulling against itself. There are seven of these balances, and a theologian who loses any one of them goes wrong.

The first is mystery and intelligibility. Theology is a reasoning activity and must be intelligible, and yet it must always guard the mystery of God and of his revelation. A theology that explains everything has explained God away.

The second is identity and change. The original language of faith in the Scriptures has a lasting value that does not pass, and yet it calls for continual reinterpretation and restatement in every age.

The third is committed and searching. Theology is a committed engagement that challenges and changes our lives, and at the same time it is a searching activity that examines all Christian beliefs, practices, and traditions in the light of present knowledge and experience.

The fourth is community and the individual theologian. Christian faith is held and handed on within a community, and the community is the place where theology is done, the *locus theologicus*. The individual theologian shares the faith and the charism of that community, and yet he also carries a prophetic role within it, sometimes calling it to conversion.

The fifth is the one and the many. The heart of Christian theology is the single Christ-event, and yet within Christianity there are many traditions, Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant, Pentecostal, and within Catholic theology many schools. One truth is experienced and yet

expressed in many ways. The Rig Veda says the same of God: *ekam sat viprah bahudha vadanti*, the truth is one, the wise call it by many names.

The sixth is universal and contextual. The theology of Thomas Aquinas was once treated as a lasting theology for the whole Church, and yet it too was the child of its own time. No theology is final. Every theology is contextual, shaped by its history, its society, and its culture, which is why we have liberation, feminist, black, Dalit, tribal, and ecological theologies.

The seventh is orthodoxy and orthopraxis. Orthodoxy is faithfulness to the original and authentic Christian faith. Orthopraxis is right doing, the concern to change the world and society. The two need each other. Doctrine that never touches life is empty, and action without truth loses its way. All theories are tested by practice, and all doctrines prove themselves living when they bear on practice.

8. The Two Foundations: Faith and Revelation

All study of theology begins with its two foundations, faith and revelation, which is why the first discipline a student meets is called fundamental theology. The Abba experience of Jesus, the Kingdom of God that the disciples saw in him, is the starting point of Christianity. This presupposes that God has revealed himself in Jesus Christ for the salvation of the world. Faith and revelation are therefore inseparable. Revelation is the self-communication of God to human beings, and faith is the human response to it. The self-revealing of God becomes complete only when a human being receives it and answers it, as Mary answered at the Annunciation with her *fiat*.

Faith is not merely the assent of the mind to a set of truths. The Letter to the Hebrews calls it the assurance of things hoped for and the conviction of things not seen, and Scripture shows it again and again as a personal encounter that transforms the whole person, the encounter of Moses at the bush, of the Samaritan woman at the well, of the disciples at the Transfiguration and at Emmaus. For the Christian this encounter is with Jesus Christ, and faith is the total response and self-gift of the whole person to God as he is revealed in Jesus. In the Old Testament, Abraham is called the father of all who believe, and faith there is rooted in the fidelity of God to his promises and his covenant. In the New Testament, faith is the acceptance of Jesus and his message, centred on the risen Lord. Mary, Joseph, Zachariah, Elizabeth, and the disciples are its models, and above all Jesus himself, who entrusted himself to his Abba through struggle and remained faithful to the end, whose "yes" to the Father was total and irrevocable. Our own faith is meant to take the shape of his.

Revelation, for its part, is the utterly free self-gift of God. God reveals himself through his deeds in history. In creation he shows himself as the author of life. In the Exodus he shows himself as liberator. In the paschal mystery he shows himself as the one who loves to the end. In the Church he shows himself as the God of a new people. The Letter to the Hebrews says that God, who spoke of old in many ways through the prophets, has in these last days spoken to us by a Son. Jesus Christ is therefore the fullness of revelation. With his

resurrection and the sending of the Spirit, no new public revelation is to be expected before his glorious return. This does not mean that God has fallen silent, for the Second Vatican Council affirms that God is present and at work in other cultures and religions and wills the salvation of all. At the centre of Christian revelation stands the Trinity, the self-disclosure of God as Father, Son, and Spirit, which the early community heard in the very prayer of Jesus, "Abba, Father." The Trinity is the source, the model, and the reference point of every human community.

9. The Sources of Theology

Theology draws its content from sources, and the three primary sources are Sacred Scripture, Sacred Tradition, and the Magisterium of the Church. The Second Vatican Council teaches that these three are so joined that none of them can stand without the others, each serving in its own way under the action of the one Holy Spirit for the salvation of the world.

Sacred Scripture is the Bible, the seventy-three books, forty-six of the Old Testament and twenty-seven of the New, which the apostolic community saw as reflecting their experience of the revelation of God in the person of Jesus Christ. The Old Testament is to be read in the light of Christ crucified and risen, and the New in the light of the Old, for the New lies hidden in the Old and the Old is unveiled in the New. The four Gospels hold the central place because Christ is their centre. Scripture is the norm that norms all other norms and is itself normed by none, and *Dei Verbum* calls it the soul of theology.

Sacred Tradition takes its name from the Latin *tradere*, to hand over. It is the handing on of the faith from one generation to the next, as Paul writes, "I received from the Lord what I also handed on to you." It is good to distinguish Tradition with a capital letter from the many small traditions. Tradition is the whole living life of the Church, rooted in the apostolic preaching and continuing to grow today, the sum of the belief, worship, and practice of the community. The small traditions are the concrete historical forms of that life, its customs, structures, and formulations, which must constantly be tested and judged by the authentic Tradition. The one Tradition is found only in and through the many traditions, and this ongoing self-communication of God is the work of the Holy Spirit. Among these living traditions are the Eastern and the Western Churches, of equal dignity, twenty-three Eastern Catholic Churches together with the Latin Church, making twenty-four Churches in full communion, following the great liturgical families of Rome, Alexandria, Antioch, Armenia, Chaldea, and Byzantium. Two of these Eastern Catholic Churches are in India, the Syro-Malabar and the Syro-Malankara.

Tradition reaches us through several carriers. The liturgy and the sacraments carry it, for in the liturgy the people share in the saving work of Christ, who is present and continues his work of redemption, and a sacrament is the visible sign of invisible grace, a prophetic and symbolic action joined to the words and deeds of Jesus and now repeated by the Church in the power of the Spirit. The creeds carry it, those short confessions that begin with *credo*, "I believe," whose centre is the Trinity, the incarnation, salvation, and eternal life, the Apostles

Creed and the Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed being the most common. Doctrines and dogmas carry it, drawn out by the Fathers of the Church and defined, in the case of a dogma, when the Magisterium exercises to the full the authority it holds from Christ. The laws and disciplines of the Church carry it as well, having their root in Scripture, gathered over the centuries and given their present form in the 1983 Code of Canon Law for the Latin Church and the 1990 Code of Canons of the Eastern Churches. The Catechism of the Catholic Church, promulgated by John Paul II in 1992, gathers all of this into four parts, the profession of faith, the celebration of the Christian mystery, life in Christ, and Christian prayer.

The Magisterium is the teaching office of the Church, the Pope and the bishops, holding a pastoral authority that comes from Christ. It is good to remember that the Magisterium is not above the Word of God but is its servant, charged with giving an authentic interpretation of that Word whether in Scripture or in Tradition. The Pope, as successor of Peter, is the visible sign of unity and has the authority, under certain strict conditions, to define matters of faith and morals, as in the dogmas of the Immaculate Conception in 1854 and the Assumption in 1950. The bishops, as successors of the apostles, form one college, and the doctrine of papal primacy taught at the First Vatican Council is completed by the doctrine of the collegiality of the bishops taught at the Second. There are two modes of this teaching authority, the ordinary, exercised in the daily preaching and guidance of the bishops in communion with the Pope, and the extraordinary, exercised by an ecumenical council or by the Pope defining a dogma from the chair of Peter.

Two further sources deserve their own word. Synodality, from the Greek *synodos*, the path walked together, is the way the whole Church listens together for the voice of the Spirit. Pope Francis describes the synod as walking together in order to meet, to listen, and to reflect, and he calls listening the hardest thing of all, because while another is speaking we are already preparing our reply. He names the cure simply: the apostolate of the ear. Synodality is not democracy but a structured conversation among all the members of the Church, bishops, priests, and laity. Closely joined to it is the *sensus fidei*, the sense of the faith, and the *sensus fidelium*, the sense of the faithful. The deposit of faith lives in the whole body of the baptised, who share by their baptism in the priestly, prophetic, and pastoral office of Christ. The Magisterium listens to and consults this sense of the whole Church before it judges in matters of faith and morals, and it is the task of theology to discern this sense of the faithful, to make it clear, and to interpret it for the times.

10. The Resources of Theology

Besides these sources, theology has resources, places where God is present and active in the world through people and their experience. The first resource is human experience itself, for the revelation of God reaches the human person through experience, and so experience is the starting point of all religious and theological searching. Human experience is stored in art, architecture, music, dance, story, poetry, literature, and philosophy, and both the past experience of a people and its present experience must be weighed in theology.

The second resource is the socio-cultural heritage of a people, that whole vision and way of life that holds together its values, signs, symbols, customs, arts, myths, and folklore. Cultures are living things that change through their meetings with other cultures. No culture is higher or lower than another. All are unique and equally valid, and the right attitude joins rootedness in one's own culture with openness to others. Since God speaks to human beings according to their cultures, the old methods of mission that simply imposed one culture on all the rest must change in favour of openness, listening, and dialogue.

The third resource is the variety of religious traditions. The Church has moved a long way, from the old saying that outside the Church there is no salvation to the teaching of the universal saving will of God. The Council teaches that salvation is offered to all who strive to do the will of God as they know it through conscience, and that people are saved not in spite of their religions but, in a real sense, in and through them, because God has been reaching out to them within their own life and history. Every religion reflects a ray of the truth that enlightens everyone, and the Church urges her members to acknowledge and promote the spiritual and moral goods found in other religions, attending to their scriptures, myths, and stories, so as to build together one community of freedom, fellowship, and justice.

The fourth resource is the movements of the people and the voice of those pushed to the margins. The Exodus marks the beginning of the movements of the people, and the story of Jesus and the Kingdom is their summit. Theology must attend to the voices of the marginalised, for they are the place of the Word and the action of God in the world today. The poor, the *anawim*, were always the beloved of God in both Testaments. God takes the side of the poor and of the victims of society, since poverty, slavery, and oppression are made by human hands and stand against the vision of the Kingdom. The Church and her theology must therefore hold a preferential love for the poor and listen to their cry for life.

The fifth resource is the contribution of the other sciences. The natural sciences answer many questions of how, but they cannot answer the deep questions of why, the questions of meaning that arise from human life, and here theology and science are meant to work as partners, as in the dialogue between moral theology and medicine. The human and social sciences, sociology, anthropology, psychology, economics, and political science, give theology tools to understand reality, and contemporary theology uses them and then reaches past understanding toward the transforming of reality, as liberation, contextual, and Dalit theology do. This marks a shift from studying theology to doing theology, resting on four pillars, Scripture, Tradition, faith experience, and the social context.

Here social analysis finds its place. It is one step in the method of theologising, not the whole of it, and not even the first step. The first step is commitment to and solidarity with the people of God, an insertion that echoes the incarnation and our own baptism. Then comes the use of the social sciences to analyse the situation, the long look at the sheep who are without a shepherd. Then comes theological reflection, in which earlier theology and earlier readings of Scripture are examined again in the light of the new social reality and measured against the ideal of the Kingdom and the Abba experience. And then comes the proposal of a plan of action, which has the shape of self-emptying and of the cross, of

passion, death, and resurrection. India is a land rich in culture, religion, and natural and human resources, and yet it is marked by harsh poverty, by inhuman discrimination, by religious bigotry and fundamentalism, by a growing disregard for the weaker sections, and by violence, corruption, and consumerism. To these realities theology must speak.

11. The History of Theology

Theology is the meeting of the human person with God, and it is fair to ask when that meeting, and so theology itself, began. Did it begin with the story of creation, with the experience of liberation in the Exodus, with the Christ-event, with the early Fathers, with the councils? It is best to see theology as developing through several great periods, each one trying to answer the question its own age was asking.

Biblical theology is the reflection of the inspired authors themselves. The Council teaches a twofold authorship of Scripture, divine and human. God did not dictate the words mechanically. He chose human authors who used their own powers fully, so that, with God acting in them and through them, they wrote as true authors all that he wanted written, and no more. In the Old Testament we find the Yahwist, the Elohist, the Priestly, the Deuteronomic, the wisdom, and the prophetic streams, gathered around creation, election, liberation, law, covenant, the chosen people, and the expectation of the Kingdom. In the New Testament we find the self-communication of God in Jesus Christ for the salvation of all, with the Christ-event as its centre. Already in the New Testament there is not one Christology but many, a backward-reaching reflection that moves from the resurrection to the ministry to the very pre-existence of the Word, expressed as the Logos in John, the Messiah in the Synoptics and Acts, the cosmic Christ in Ephesians and Colossians, the high priest in Hebrews. The many Christologies share one centre: that Jesus is the bearer of salvation from God, that the very name Jesus means God saves.

Patristic theology is the work of the Fathers of the Church, the writers of antiquity marked by soundness of doctrine, holiness of life, the approval of the Church, and nearness to the apostolic age, from the apostolic age until roughly the eighth century. Among them are the apostolic Fathers, who taught and exhorted, the apologists, who defended the faith, and the great doctrinal theologians, who set the faith in order. In their time the canon of the New Testament was fixed, the creeds were formed, the doctrine of the Trinity was clarified as one God in three persons, and the Christological question was settled at the Council of Chalcedon in 451, which confessed Christ as one person in two natures, truly divine and truly human. Two schools shaped this work, the Alexandrian, which stressed the divinity of Christ and could underplay his humanity, and the Antiochene, which stressed his full humanity and could loosen its union with his divinity. Great names stand out, among them Clement of Alexandria, Origen, the Cappadocian Fathers Gregory of Nazianzus, Basil of Caesarea, and Gregory of Nyssa in the Greek world, and Tertullian, Ambrose, and Augustine in the Latin.

These differences hardened into distinct models. The Greek model, centred at Alexandria, met the Gospel with the Greek world and began its account of the Trinity from the three

persons, understood as one God. The Latin model, at Rome and Carthage, met Latin culture through Hippolytus, Tertullian, Ambrose, and Augustine, and began from the one God and then spoke of the three persons. The Syriac model, carried above all by Ephrem the Syrian, brought a Semitic vision into Christian theology and gave us the first Christian tradition in India, the Thomas Christians of the Malabar coast. For the Syriac tradition God cannot be caught in definitions, and poetry is the fitting language of theology, full of symbol, metaphor, love, wonder, and awe, with faith as the luminous eye by which the human person comes to know God.

These same East and West tendencies bore on the first great division of the Church. The dispute over the *Filioque*, over whether the Spirit proceeds from the Father alone or from the Father and the Son, joined to questions of authority and culture, led to the East-West Schism. In 1054 the legates of the Pope, led by Cardinal Humbert, excommunicated the Patriarch of Constantinople, Michael Cerularius, and the Patriarch in turn excommunicated the legates, and the two halves of the Church drifted apart.

Scholastic theology arose in the medieval schools, from which it takes its name, and sought to unite the philosophy of Aristotle with Christian doctrine, reconciling faith and reason. It moved through its early, high, and late phases and produced the systems known as Thomism, Scotism, and Ockhamism. Anselm of Canterbury, the father of Scholasticism, gave it the watchword *fides quaerens intellectum*. Bernard of Clairvaux held to a mystical theology of personal experience, the knowing of Jesus and him crucified. Thomas Aquinas built the great synthesis with the primacy of the intellect, Bonaventure a synthesis with the primacy of the will, John Duns Scotus a Christ-centred synthesis in which God reveals his love in the incarnation, and William of Ockham opened the modern way with his principle that nothing should be affirmed without reason, unless it is self-evident, known by experience, or held on the authority of Scripture.

The sixteenth century brought the Reformation and what may be called the kerygmatic model, gathered around the cries of *sola scriptura*, *sola fide*, and *sola gratia*, Scripture alone, faith alone, grace alone. Here theology is the science that seeks to hear and to speak of the God who reveals himself in the Word, and the human being is the creature and debtor who cannot save himself and is upheld only by grace. The modern period that followed saw the recovery of Scholastic thought under Leo XIII and also new beginnings, such as the work of Gabriel Marcel, who distinguished a problem, which can be solved from the outside, from a mystery, which can only be entered, and who taught that the place of human existence is not the lonely "I" but the shared "we."

The turning point of the modern Church was the Second Vatican Council of 1962 to 1965, the twenty-first ecumenical council, called by John XXIII and continued by Paul VI. It had a twofold purpose, *aggiornamento*, the bringing of the Church up to date, and *riunione*, the search for Christian unity. Through its sixteen documents, four constitutions, nine decrees, and three declarations, it renewed the understanding of the Church, of formation, of the world, of other religions, of salvation, of dialogue, of culture, and of the liturgy. In the more than fifty years since the Council, the Church has wrestled with questions of authority and collegiality, of synodality and lay participation, amid the pressures of clericalism,

secularism, globalisation, and a many-religioned world, and out of this period the contextual theologies have come.

One further modern current deserves mention, the theological anthropology of Karl Rahner. Theology, on this view, is at once God seeking the human being, asking as in the garden, "Where are you," and the human being seeking God, as the deer longs for running water in Psalm 42. The human being is the finite creature who is open to the infinite, whose very existence is oriented toward God, what Rahner called the supernatural existential. For Rahner, God and humanity are correlative terms, and the proper object of theology is not God considered in himself but the human person in relation to God, so that all the questions of theology, of Christology, of the Trinity, can rightly be approached through the human person.

12. The Models of Theology

Because every theology is contextual, theologians have described several models of how faith and culture are brought together. The translation model stays faithful to the inherited faith tradition and carries it into a new culture, though at times at the cost of the culture itself. The anthropological model places the cultural context and the human person within that context at the centre. The synthetic model seeks a balance between the inherited faith and the cultural context. The transcendental model attends to the mysteries of theology and to the knowing subject, moving past a narrow handing-on of formulas. Stephen Bevens, whose work we shall use later in the course, sets out six such models in all, adding the praxis model and the countercultural model to these, and it is worth knowing that the streams of contextual theology, liberation, Dalit, Indian, and the rest, are not a confusion but different models doing the same work in different ways.

Two models deserve special attention for us in India. The contemplative model grows from the tradition of the *ashram* and of *sannyasa*, and reads Christian faith through the threefold Indian path to God. On the path of knowledge, *jnana marga*, God is found in the cave of the heart as *Saccidananda*, being, awareness, and bliss, in an oneness that the Hindu names with *aham brahmasmi* and the Christian may name as *koinonia*, communion. On the path of devotion, *bhakti marga*, God is related to as the personal Lord, and the devotee lives the bond of the vine and the branches. On the path of action, *karma marga*, God is found on the Indian road in the building of human community, in the spirit of *vasudhaiva kutumbakam*, the whole world as one family. The pioneers of this model in the Catholic Church were Swami Parama Arubi Anandam, Swami Abhishiktananda, and Bede Griffiths, Swami Dayananda, of the Saccidananda Ashram at Shantivanam.

The praxis model is the model of liberation theology, born in Latin America in the nineteen sixties as a theology from below, bound up with action. It reads the God of history in the burning bush of Exodus, in the manifesto of Jesus in Luke 4, and in the judgment scene of Matthew 25, and it holds that genuine theology is possible only where there is a freeing commitment to the poor. It analyses the situation, sees the human person as one who carries the dignity of God, and announces the promise of salvation given in Jesus. This

model has given rise to many others, the subaltern, the black, the feminist, the Dalit, the tribal, and the Korean Minjung theologies, and it presses us to theologise out of the many-sided reality of India.

13. Theologizing in India

All our courses are to be approached through the lens of Indianness, through Indian history, the analysis of Indian reality, the study of the problems of the subaltern, and the Indian religions, with the questions of justice and ecology running through everything. The image the professor gives is sharp. To do theology in India is to enter the Jordan of the religions and the Calvary of poverty, and to be crucified there with the struggles of the people. There is a paradigm shift from the bird view to the worm view, from a dogmatic, Sanskritic, advaitic, Church-oriented theology done as it were from a helicopter, to a theology of the Dalit, the tribal, the woman, and the marginalised, done from the ground, like a bullock cart, oriented to a people-centred Church.

We cannot theologise in India without knowing the Christian traditions that already live here. The oldest is the tradition of the apostle Thomas, who by ancient account came to Kodungallur near Kochi in the year 52 and was martyred at Mylapore in the year 72. The Thomas Christians have been described as Hindu in culture, Christian in faith, and Syrian in worship, and through their link with the East Syrian Church their Christology kept a strong devotion to the humanity of Jesus. Today their descendants are found in several Churches of Saint Thomas, Catholic, Orthodox, and Reformed. An older tradition speaks also of the apostle Bartholomew near present-day Mumbai, and of the Gospel of Matthew in Hebrew found among Indian Christians in the second century. The Roman Catholic tradition in the modern sense dates from the sixteenth century, from the Franciscans, from the first bishopric at Goa in 1534, and from Francis Xavier on the Fishery Coast, and it produced great experiments in inculturation, above all Robert de Nobili, who took up the life of a *sannyasi*, learned Sanskrit and the Vedas, and wrote in Indian literary forms, and Thomas Stephens, whose *Kristapurana* told the Christian story in the shape of an Indian *purana*. The Protestant tradition opened with the translation work of William Carey and his companions at Serampore and the printing press that carried Christian literature across the land.

The encounter of Christ with India also stirred a renaissance. Educated Hindus such as Raja Ram Mohan Roy and Keshab Chandra Sen, moved in part by Christian ideals, challenged *sati*, child marriage, polygamy, untouchability, and the abuses of caste. Many pioneers, Hindu and Christian, foreign and Indian, gave a direction to Indian Christian theology, among them Brahmabandhab Upadhyay with his idea of the Hindu-Christian, Sadhu Sundar Singh, Chakkarai and Appasamy with their Christian *bhakti*, and M. M. Thomas, Stanley Samartha, George Soares-Prabhu, and Sebastian Kappen with their vision of a prophetic Church.

From this soil grow the contextual theologies of India. The Indian theology of liberation seeks to discern the action of God in history and to work with God in the transforming of

the world, so that the people may be set free from every force of oppression, and it holds that the special love of the Church for the poor and the marginalised must never be bargained away. Subaltern theology is the cry of the groups of lower rank, by caste, class, gender, or ethnicity, who express their faith in the midst of their agony, drawing on their own myths, stories, songs, and rituals, with the crucified Jesus at the centre giving meaning to their suffering and the risen Lord giving hope for a new world.

Within this family, Dalit theology takes its name from the word *dalit*, which means broken, crushed, torn apart. It is the reflection of Dalit Christians on the Gospel in the light of their own circumstances, a theology from below. It can be a theology about the Dalits, a reflection on Christian responsibility toward them, a theology for the Dalits, addressed to them, and above all a theology by the Dalits, written by Dalit theologians such as Arvind P. Nirmal. It draws on human dignity, on the image and likeness of God, on the table fellowship of Jesus, and on the picture of Jesus himself as the Dalit, the suffering servant who knew the experience of being forsaken by God and yet was raised, giving hope and mission.

Tribal theology speaks for the indigenous peoples of India, the *adivasis*, the most exploited owners of the land, who carry a history of defeat, displacement, and conquest, often driven from their homes by dams and mines without compensation. Its heart is the bond of land, forest, and water, *jal, jangal, jamin*, an ecological theology in which the land is mother, who feeds, bears, and sustains, and at the same time holy ground, as at the burning bush, where the sandals must come off. It reads the whole creation as groaning to regain the original blessing of Genesis, and it calls the human being to be a steward and not a master, since the land belongs to God and cannot finally be sold. Tribal theology offers a holistic liberation that joins the social, the economic, the cultural, the political, and the ecological, a salvation not only of persons and societies but of all creation, expressed not in cold method but in symbol and life, in dance and drum, earth and water, fire and air.

Feminist theology arises from the long history in which theologies of the past and present have carried the standpoint, the concerns, and the domination of men, with the tragic result of the subordination and exploitation of women, who in many cultures are treated as things to be used. The reality is not abstract. In one recent and disturbing case in Gujarat, more than sixty young women in a hostel were forced to remove their undergarments so that the staff could check whether they were menstruating, because those who were menstruating had been forbidden to eat with the others. Such cruelty, dressed up as religion, shows why theology needs the corrective of the experience of women. The standpoint, the insights, and the intuitions of women are not optional extras but are needed for an authentic and balanced theology, one warmed by the caring and sharing that women bring.

Theology of dialogue rests on the conviction that God is greater than every religion, that the truth is one though the wise name it in many ways, and that no one holds a monopoly on the knowledge of God. The Christian God is Trinity, communion and harmony, a being for the other, and the First Letter to Timothy teaches that God wills all to be saved, that all share a common origin and a common destiny. The incarnation is itself the dialogue of God with humanity in solidarity, and the Kingdom that Jesus preaches breaks down barriers for the sake of freedom, fellowship, and justice. Pluralism in India is therefore not a problem to be

removed but a reality to be lived, with a convergence sought between the theologising that begins from culture, philosophy, and religion and the theologising that begins from the social, economic, and political context, the convergence of the paths of knowledge, devotion, and action. This calls for collaboration, networking, and dialogue at every level among the Churches and the communities of India.

Ecological theology reads the whole creation as the dwelling of God. As the poet wrote, the earth is crammed with heaven, and every common bush is afire with God, but only the one who sees takes off his shoes, while the rest sit round and pluck blackberries. The Scriptures present the world as sacrament, whose first cause is God, in which the birds and the flowers sing his praise and the air and the water signal his providence. Grace breaks through whenever creation gives praise, and whenever a human being loves and labours, weeps and struggles with the downtrodden, stands for the truth, and carries the daily cross, for then the human person and the whole creation become the visible sign of the invisible grace of God. The whole world is, as it were, an unconsecrated host, longing to be transformed by our love and commitment into the host of Christ, moving toward the Omega who is Christ. To find God in all things, as Saint Ignatius teaches in the Spiritual Exercises, we need a certain inner sight, the divine eye, the *divyacaksu*, with which Arjuna saw and the disciples on the road to Emmaus came to see, for the whole creation is pervaded by the divine: *ishavasyam idam sarvam*, the Lord dwells in all that is.

Finally, the ecumenical concern runs through all of this. The one Church of Jesus Christ has been divided by doctrine, by politics, by ethnicity, and too often by the hunger for power, and there have been efforts again and again to obey the prayer of Jesus that they may all be one. The Council teaches that baptism is already a bond of unity and a seed of full unity among divided Christians, and Pope Francis speaks of an ecumenism of blood, the unity of Christians who are persecuted and who die together for the name of Christ. The existence of different Churches is a standing reminder of two things at once, the need for unity and the respect owed to a healthy plurality.

14. The Branches of Theology

The one work of theology divides into branches, each studying the one mystery from its own angle, and a student should know the map before setting out. Fundamental theology reflects on the foundations themselves, on the revelation of the Triune God in Jesus Christ, on the reception of revelation in faith, on the credibility of revelation, and on its handing on and interpretation. Biblical theology studies the Word of God in the Old and New Testaments with the proper tools of interpretation, since Scripture is the unique source and norm of the faith experience of the community, set down in writing under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit. Systematic or dogmatic theology reflects in an orderly way on the doctrines of the Church and tries to state them in language that has meaning for the community today, taking up Christology, the Trinity, the Holy Spirit, Mary, the Church, theological anthropology, grace, the sacraments, and the last things. Moral theology, with canon law, studies the shape of Christian living on the basis of the revealed Word, and takes up the

questions of human life, of medical and sexual ethics, of marriage, and of social justice. Spiritual theology studies the life of prayer and holiness in the various spiritualities of East and West and of the founders and mystics. Pastoral theology studies the care of the community, the Word, the liturgy, catechesis, counselling, preaching, and the celebration of the sacraments. Historical theology, with missiology, studies the history of the Church, the development of doctrine, the methods of evangelisation, and the meeting of cultures and religions, with special attention in our setting to the history and the theology of the Christian traditions of India and to the dialogue with other religions.

15. A Closing Word: The Burning Bush

The course returns at its end to where it began, to the burning bush. The bush still burns in India, in the cry of the poor, of the Dalit, of the tribal, of the woman, and of the wounded earth, and the same God still says, "I have heard the cry of my people; come, I will send you." The question for each of us is whether the bush is beckoning us, and whether we will turn aside to look, and take off our sandals, and listen. Theology done with rigour and with prayer, immersed in the context, celebrated in the liturgy, and grounded in a strong personal faith in Christ and his mission of the Kingdom, is one of the ways we answer that call. May the light of knowledge and the light of a holy life shine together in you, so that, in the words of the seminary, your light may shine before others.

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